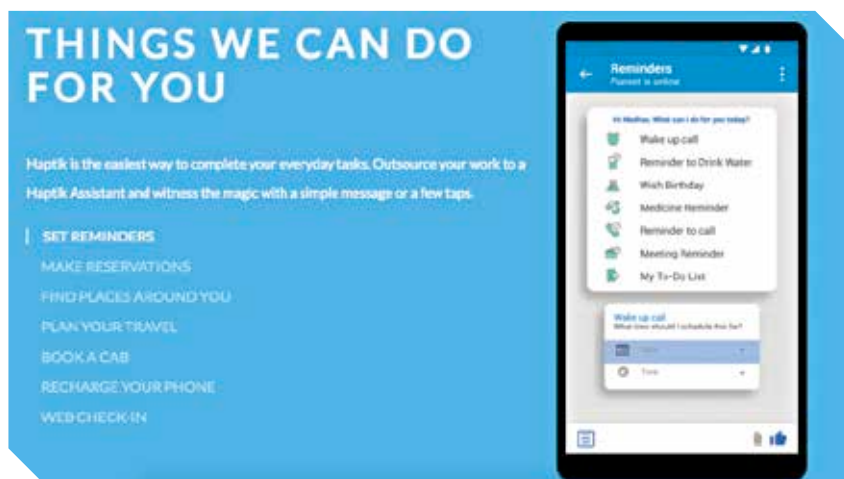




One of the highest rated apps in India, Haptik provides a lot of services via chat

to help us, be it from the local grocery shop owner who suggests the fruit, or the tailor who tells you about trending fashion. Another factor is that Indians especially, are already used to off-loading work onto maids, drivers, and other blue-collar job workers. However, chatbots are becoming popular among millennials, who have neither gone to the kind of stores mentioned earlier, or utilised dedicated blue-collar services as much. So what factors influence chatbots?

First - Instant messaging platforms have become ubiquitous and people have mastered texting as a platform long ago. Even language isn't a barrier anymore, with multilingual keyboards and support for multiple languages on virtual assistants becoming quite common. Second - and more importantly, it removes the paradox of choice. We're so spoiled for choice, that we often can't choose anything!

MISTAKEN

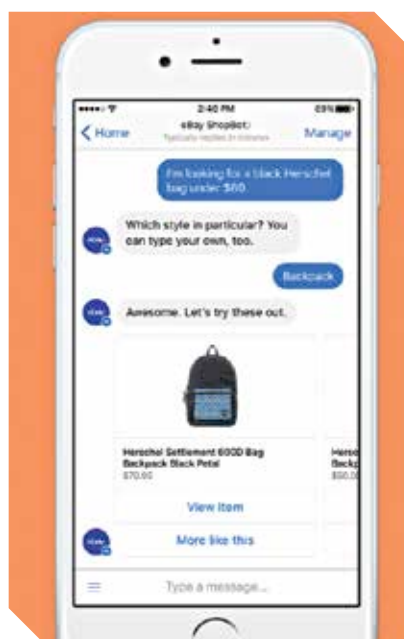
If you were waiting for the section with the cons, congrats, you finally got there. However, if you're looking for a shoulder to cry on while you say AI will take our jobs, leave our shoulders out of it.

Also, in their current state, AI chatbots are not truly creative. "AI still cannot perform any task that requires creativity, or coming up with new ideas that are not resolved using a set pattern", says Jaiswal. "For example, using the previously stated bus booking case, if the user was a 60-year old man making the booking for him-

self and his wife, a human being may not recommend a night bus to them due to various concerns. An AI bot on the other hand, cannot make this differentiation unless specifically told to do so by the creators."

GOING FORWARD

Developments in deep learning, AI, and natural language processing are showing a lot of promise when it comes to enhancing the average shopping experience. Thinking of chatbots as the only possible AI implementation when it comes to shopping is sheer short sightedness. There are quite a few new applications that are gradually gaining popularity.



eBay's shopping bot 'Shopbot' lets you shop while you chat

Visual search is one such area. Machine learning has taken a step forward by being able to identify objects and patterns within images. Take the example of Pinterest Lens – a technology based on the previously implemented visual search, related pins, and guided search on Pinterest – which uses your smartphone camera to identify real world objects in your images and serve up similar images from websites, making it easier for you to find and purchase the object online.

Beyond direct retail, AI will also affect purchase decisions indirectly with deep learning. As Gaurav Gandhi, COO, Viacom18 Digital Ventures explains about Voot, an OTT content platform, "We now better understand levels of ad fatigue, ideal places to insert advertising between content, making user/audience groups for targeting, better targeted marketing plans for our shows, levels of cross promotion and cross usage between genres, best time to publish new shows, how many notifications to send out and at what time – among others – all thanks to data insights."

SHOP TILL YOU DROP

As with other aspects of AI, chatbots aren't perfect yet. Recent debacles like that of Tay prove how machine learning could easily go wrong if not monitored. On the other hand, even with proven results, traditional stores aren't really eager to jump onto the AI bandwagon. As Tanay Dixit, Co-Founder and Product Head, Talespin puts it, "While investors are generally excited about AI, deep learning, and chatbots, many remain cautious and the same can even be said about customers. Having said that, the lack of access to reams of data to build solutions for particular use cases is a challenge. In the search of data, companies may move into uncharted territories leading to privacy and infringement issues."

That being said, there is no doubt that in the coming years, you'll most likely be shopping, and living, aided by bots – on your phone and in your stores. Make sure to keep those credit cards handy, and those bank accounts filled - because the last time we checked, bots don't maintain tabs. 